



LECTURE :46



Sustainable Leadership

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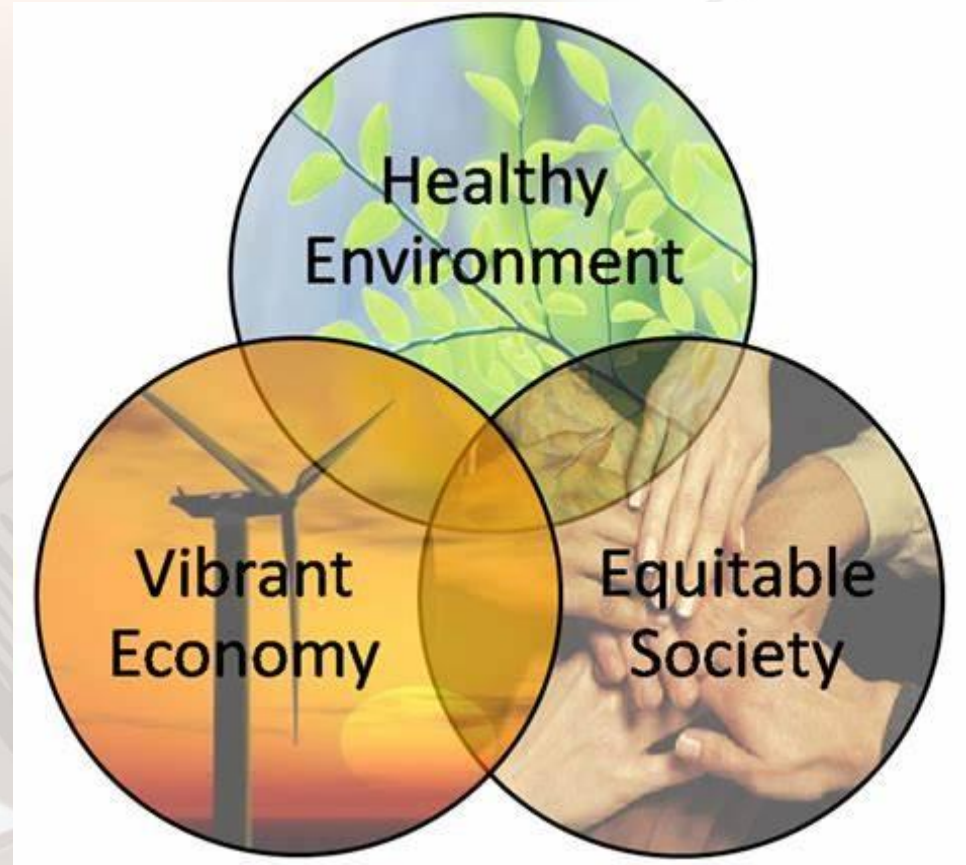
- Why do we need sustainable leaders?

- What is sustainable leadership?

- Leadership is about envisioning and shaping the future,

- Sustainable leaders look beyond immediate, short-term gains to see the role their organization plays in a larger context.

- They set strategies and ensure the delivery of results that meet the triple bottom line of social, environmental and financial performance.



- **Need of the Hour**

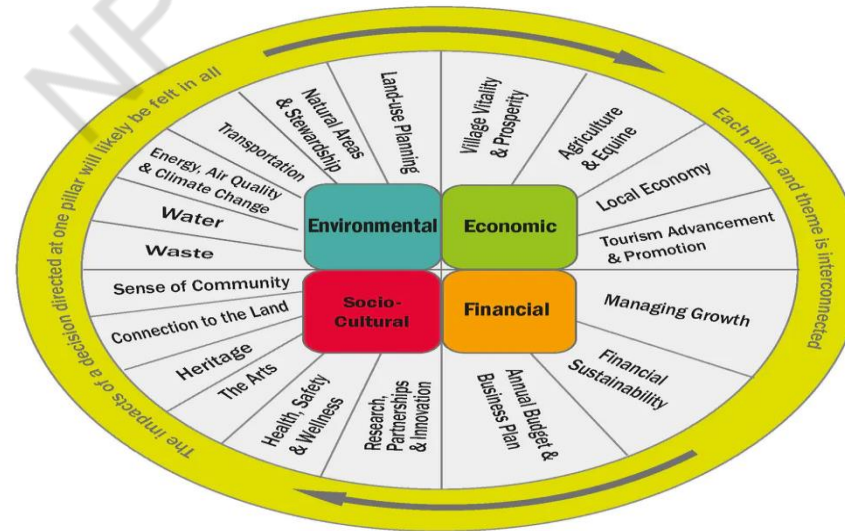
- In recent years, mounting social pressure has contributed to a **significant shift in the type of leadership seen across businesses** – from startups in their infancy, to multinational corporations.
- The challenges of today's times in the modern world are huge and **complex multiple challenges** such as **unequal development, rising population, diminishing natural resource base, climate change** and many others.
- While there is a plethora of technical solutions, the question is, **do having technical solutions suffice?**
- **Are there more factors to be addressed and enrolled**, for the very many innovations to be embedded in the development thinking and sustain therein because of the increased wellbeing generated for all sections in a society.
- **Is there not a need to think and plan** in a way that **today's solutions do not become tomorrow's problems?**

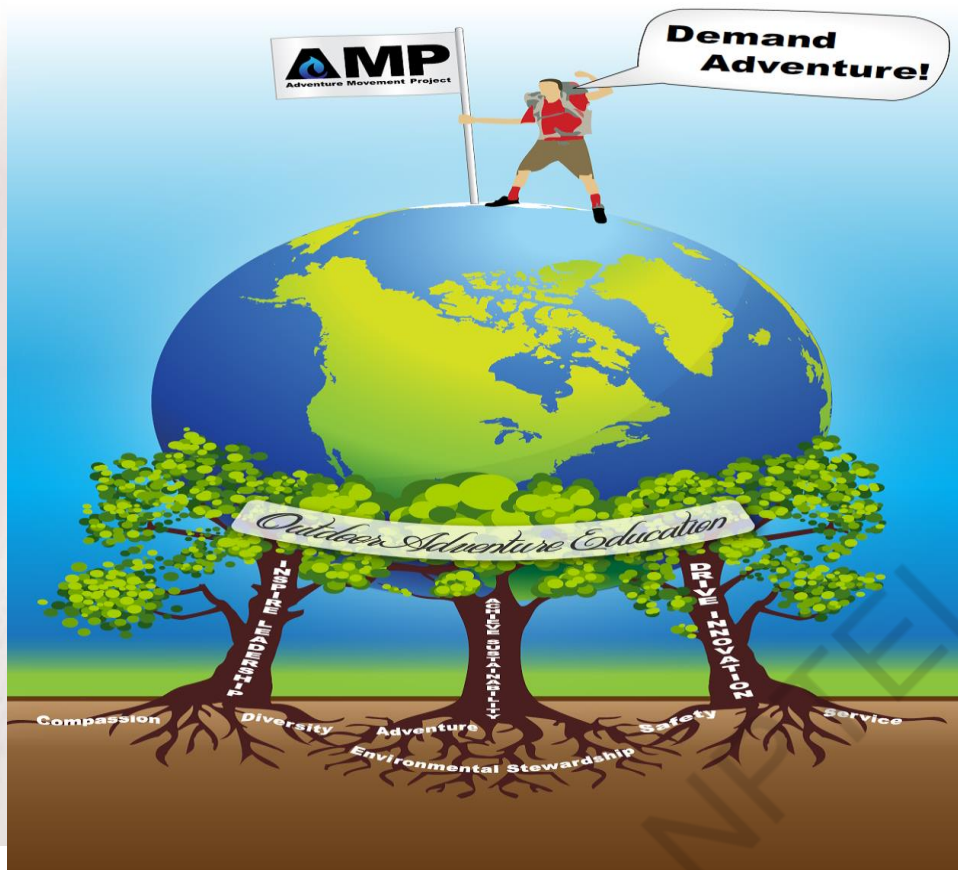


- While the technical solutions address a part of the puzzle, to address the adaptive complexities in today's world, **we need Leaders- who are the change makers, the catalysts, the enablers of change who can take along different stakeholders**, often with different (and colliding) interests and adapt the solutions through a win-win approach.
- Leaders **who can see the interconnectedness between various issues** and **take a holistic approach** while going forward
- As the world becomes increasingly aware of the impact businesses have on the triple bottom line, also known as the **three P's – people, planet and profit** – it's **important** for those at the top **to embrace sustainable leadership**.
- **Organizations** are increasingly expected **to take responsibility** for the ways in which their **activities impact their customers and workers, the wider society** and the **natural environment**.



- There is an **urgent need in business today for a new type of leadership**—one that makes the **long-term sustainability** of our world a top priority. Business leaders have an important part to play in **making the right strategic choices in order to create this sustainable future.**





Leadership & Sustainability

- Sustainability challenges are increasingly interconnected across traditional disciplines & geographies
- Social & organizational challenges are going to share and be shaped by this revolution
- All leaders, no matter what sphere they are operating in, must attend to sustainability challenges





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Behaviors of sustainable leaders

The following eight leadership behaviors are needed for leaders to implement corporate sustainability and CSR and, thereby, create and maintain a sustainable organization (D'Amato et al., 2009).



➤ There is growing social pressure on companies to consider “people , planet and profit” and to respond to the concerns of multiple stakeholders, both inside and outside the business.

➤ Organizations, are in desperate need of sustainable leaders who can balance short-term and long-term priorities and create value for a variety of stakeholders.

PEOPLE
engaging people in positive behaviors

FACILITIES
reducing the financial and environmental impact of the built environment



RESOURCES
optimizing the flow and consumption of resources

ORGANIZATION
establishing culture and strategic goals to save money and create a thriving workplace

These can be broken down into three main areas:



Sustainability mindset

A strong interior sense of purpose combined with a long-term orientation and an inherent motivation to meet the triple bottom line.



Systems thinking

The intellectual flexibility to see the bigger picture, as well as to appreciate the details—and to shift perspective between competing interests in order to develop a strategy that inspires all stakeholders.



Relationship building

An understanding of people across cultures; an advocate of diversity; and the building of productive, long-term relationships with key stakeholders.



- Key competencies of sustainable leaders



1 Sustainability mindset—moving from “me” to “we”

Sustainable leaders have a strong interior sense of purpose that grows into a stronger sense of purpose and mission within the organization. They are oriented toward the long term. They feel an inherent motivation to meet the triple bottom line of social, environmental and financial performance or “people, planet and profit.” Special competencies that sustainable leaders possess include the following:

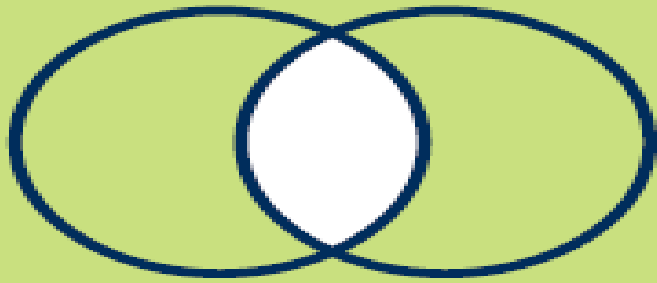
- **Enlightened self-interest:** Valuing the interests of stakeholders rather than using people for individual gain (Crane et al., 2004). Seeing stakeholders in the broadest sense; for example, including future generations.
- **Long-term orientation:** Focusing on long-term goals and not being dissuaded by pressure from parties with different and competing goals while being aware that there is no long-term success without short-term delivery (Hind et al., 2009).
- **“Presencing”:** Achieving one’s highest future potential through a combination of sensing (feeling one’s future possibility or purpose) and presence (the state of being in the present moment). Inspiring others and working together in the pursuit of a vision. Integrating careful observation of a situation, quiet reflection, reaction to feedback and then decisive action

what they love and loving what they do” with being deeply immersed in the world (Gitsham et al., 2009; Senge et al., 2004; Scharmer et al., 2013).

- **Courage:** Being driven to overcome resistance and keep up momentum toward desired goals. Making decisions in uncertain conditions, unhindered by an overload or lack of information (Hind et al., 2009).
- **Integrity:** Demonstrating honesty and moral values in both their professional and personal life so that stakeholders see sustainable leaders as role models (Hind et al., 2009).
- **Open-mindedness:** Displaying an unprejudiced attitude toward new ideas and the beliefs of other stakeholders (Hind et al., 2009).
- **Transparency:** Disclosing the bad news, as well as the good. Offering both positive and critical feedback to reinforce the best behavior in others while curtailing the worst (D’Amato et al., 2009).

We believe that a sustainability mindset is the foundation and defining aspect of sustainable leadership and that two important aspects—having a strategic outlook and building networks of stakeholder relationships—are driven by this mindset.





2 Systems thinking— zooming in and out

Sustainable leaders are adept at systems thinking and always will be aware that there is a bigger context beyond the immediate focus of the organization. They have the intellectual flexibility to see the big picture, as well as the capability to analyze the details of a strategy, and can shift perspectives quickly and frequently where necessary. Sustainable leaders can formulate a vision that inspires all stakeholders and can decide between competing interests:

- **Seeing the bigger picture:** Realizing that there always is a bigger picture (Sir David Brown, personal communication, 2014). Engineering an advantageous future for their organization through awareness of wider, more complex systems beyond the organization, with a deep understanding of how to manage the competing demands of different stakeholder groups (Senge, 1990; Hind et al., 2009; Waddock, 2007).
- **Appreciating the details:** Recognizing that successful execution of a strategy depends on getting the details right. Willing to zoom in as required to get to the root cause of an issue and zoom out equally fast to regain the big-picture perspective.
- **Maintaining balanced decision making:** Considering both global and local perspectives to make and gain support for well-founded decisions (Hind et al., 2009).
- **Keeping it simple:** Fundamentally understanding one's business, products, organization and processes. Ruthlessly eliminating complexity wherever possible. Developing products, services and solutions that serve a clear customer need and that easily can be explained to all major stakeholders.





3 Relationship building—connecting and collaborating

Sustainable leaders understand people across cultures; embrace diversity; and build productive, long-term relationships with key stakeholders through dialogue, leading to concrete and positive results:

- **Understanding across cultures:** Enhancing the knowledge and ability to recognize, interpret and react appropriately to people, organizations and other stakeholders (Talalakina, 2010; Waddock, 2007).
- **Appreciating and embracing diversity:** Eliminating unfair treatment and maximizing the potential stakeholder benefits of a diverse organization (Jackson et al., 2004; Waddock, 2007).
- **Networking:** Recognizing and acting upon sustainable business opportunities and building new relationships with stakeholders (Gitsham et al., 2009).
- **Facilitating meaningful dialogue:** Sharpening listening skills, demonstrating the ability to make decisions on a collective basis and exhibiting a willingness to encourage a sustainable language. Convincing skeptical stakeholders of the benefits of a sustainable course of action. Managing conflicts, mediating between different stakeholder interests and aligning them with the desired outcomes of the organization.
- **Empowering:** Giving stakeholders autonomy, allowing them to solve problems in new ways, and providing the intellectual stimulation to engage with their work and the sustainability objective (Waldman et al., 2006).
- **Measuring improvements:** Fine-tuning the analytical and reflective ability to measure improvements on multiple dimensions beyond bottom-line results. Gauging the impact that decisions will have on various stakeholders and assessing whether the relationships among stakeholders show reciprocity in terms of commitments, responsibilities and benefits (D'Amato et al., 2009; Waddock, 2007).





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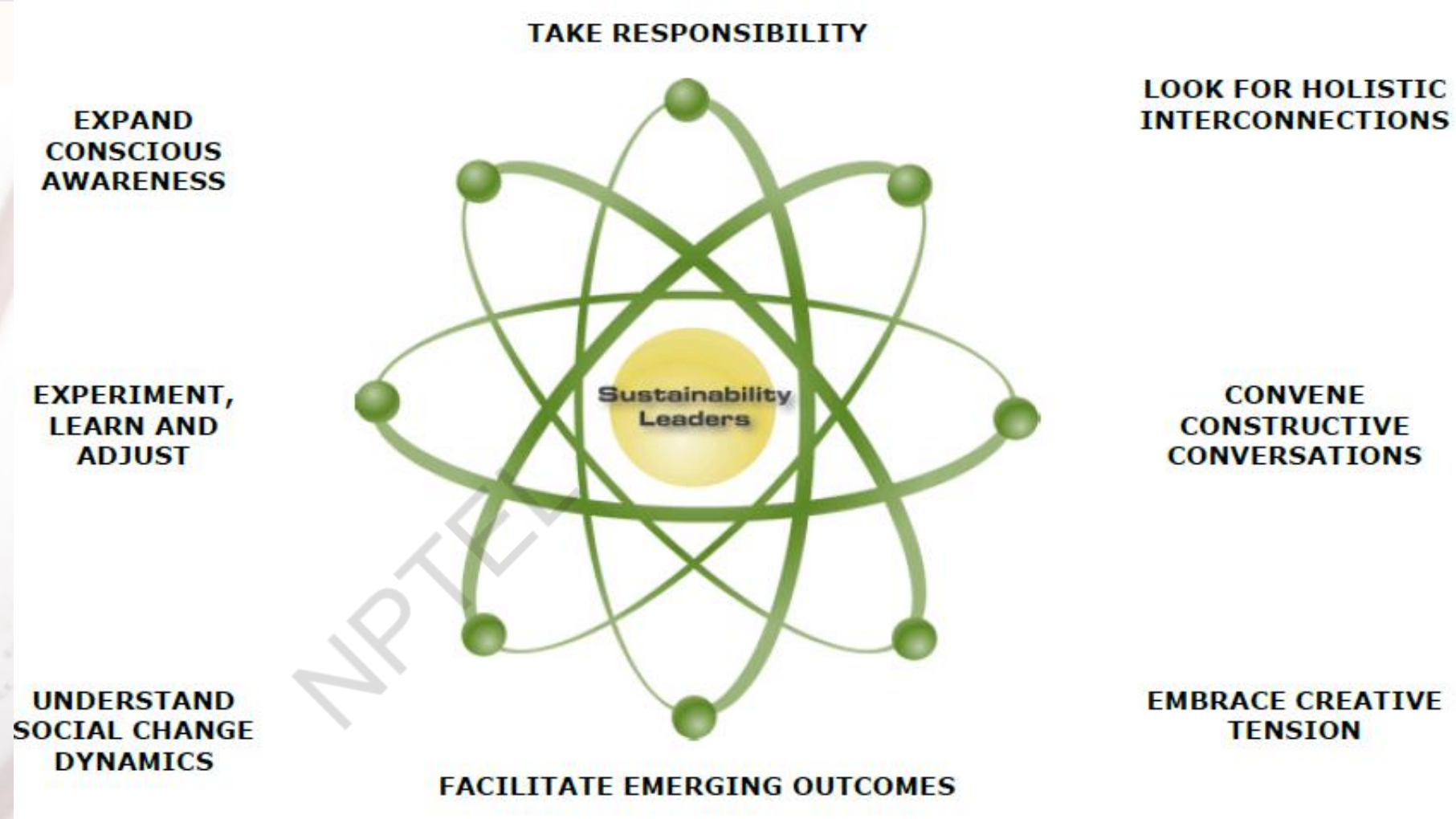
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- A sustainability leader is anyone who chooses to engage in the process of creating transformative change with others aimed toward a sustainable future; economically, environmentally and socially.



- **Sustainability Leadership Practices**
- **Take Responsibility**
- ***Making Sustainability Relevant To Others.*** Articulating the ways in which sustainability strategies are relevant to the immediate and long-term success of business, organization and community; to understand and make visible the ways in which sustainable solutions are often the best solutions for core challenges.
- ***Making Things Happen.*** Knowing how to collaboratively construct and implement strategic initiatives; Engaging in creative thinking and action within existing laws and policies while; Initiating changes in laws and policies needed to support sustainability progress; Developing techniques to hold self and others accountable for achieving agreed upon outcomes.
- ***Sustaining Energy and Momentum.*** Finding ways to sustain one's own and others' energy, momentum and belief in what is possible in the face of daunting challenges; i.e., developing practitioner communities of reflection, learning and development.



Look for Holistic Interconnections

Thinking Holistically: Being Mindful of Interdependent Connections. Building capacity for thinking holistically and recognizing relationships among seemingly independent entities or actions; producing sustainable solutions that build on one another; relate challenges and progress to what is happening within the whole.

Marshalling and Amplifying Resources for Optimal Impact. Exploring opportunities to ac
Convene Constructive Conversations

Creating Spaces for and Participating in Constructive Conversations. Inviting inquiry that stimulates one's own and others' thinking as a matter of course; crafting good questions and holding them open long enough to explore and discover perspectives and connections that might otherwise be overlooked ,

Building Authentic Relationships. Building and expanding authentic relationships for developing and implementing integrated solutions; i.e., long-term partnerships, inter-generational engagement, learning and support relationships.

Engaging Experts as Collaborators. Engaging outside resource people willing to work as part of a team in ways that invite collaboration, collective discovery and the learning needed to broaden system capability, acquire and leverage the impact of resources developed through strategic partnerships.



- **Embrace Creative Tension**
- **Inviting Diverse Voices and Perspectives:** Expanding the Network of Leaders. Inviting and acknowledging diverse points of view, while simultaneously seeking common ground and figuring out solutions for the collective good.
- **Working with Relational Power Dynamics.** Understanding the complex nuances of dynamic power relationships, and associated creative tension, when working with others whose active support is critical for learning and success.
- **Understanding and Working with Paradox, Ambiguity and Conflict.** Letting go of the need certainty in the face of contradictory “truths;” holding open the space for disagreement and conflict, recognizing that the associated tension is a potent source of energy for generating creative shifts in understanding and direction.



- **Facilitate Emerging Outcomes**
- **Continually Assessing Opportunities and Risks.** Assessing risks/opportunities associated with **sustainability strategies** (which may not be immediately visible) as outcomes unfold over time. Assessing risk of *not* employing sustainability strategies. Supporting an environment in which **calculated risks** are encouraged.
- **Understanding and Working with Paradox and Ambiguity.** Letting go of control, **certainty** and the **need to predict outcomes**; instead, engaging with others to find solutions in the face of uncertainty and contradictions.
- **Making Things Happen.** Achieving concrete results with and through others by **co-creating and abiding by agreed-upon "rules of the game" within a flexible strategic framework**. Structuring **tangible processes and agreements** for timely execution of actions and joint monitoring of accountability.



- **Understand Social Change Dynamics**
- ***Noticing and Making Sense of Patterns.***
Understanding what people do and say, individually and collectively, from a behavior pattern perspective, **experimenting with strategies** to interrupt existing patterns that **serve to galvanize the status quo.**
- ***Understanding Human Change Processes.***
Drawing from new social change models that help describe the ways in which **diverse people experience the dynamic, natural rhythms of change** in a chaotic environment **when new and unconventional ideas are being introduced.**



- **Experiment, Learn and Adjust**
- **Adapting and Using Sustainability Frameworks for Integrated Analysis and Action.** E.g., **Five Domains of Sustainable Communities** (and related Eco-Step Model), The Natural Step System Conditions, Natural Capitalism, ISO14001 environmental management systems), and SLI Leadership Engagement Framework.
- **Learning through Experimenting.** Stretching, being **willing to learn in new ways; taking calculated risks** to test emerging ideas; reflecting on and learning from experiences of all kinds; looking for unrealized potential through **experimental thinking and doing** with others.
- **Sharing Information and Knowledge as it Unfolds.** Letting others know the thinking behind decisions and action; inviting others to learn with you in process of doing; **strengthening the collective practice of experimentation, adaptation and learning.**





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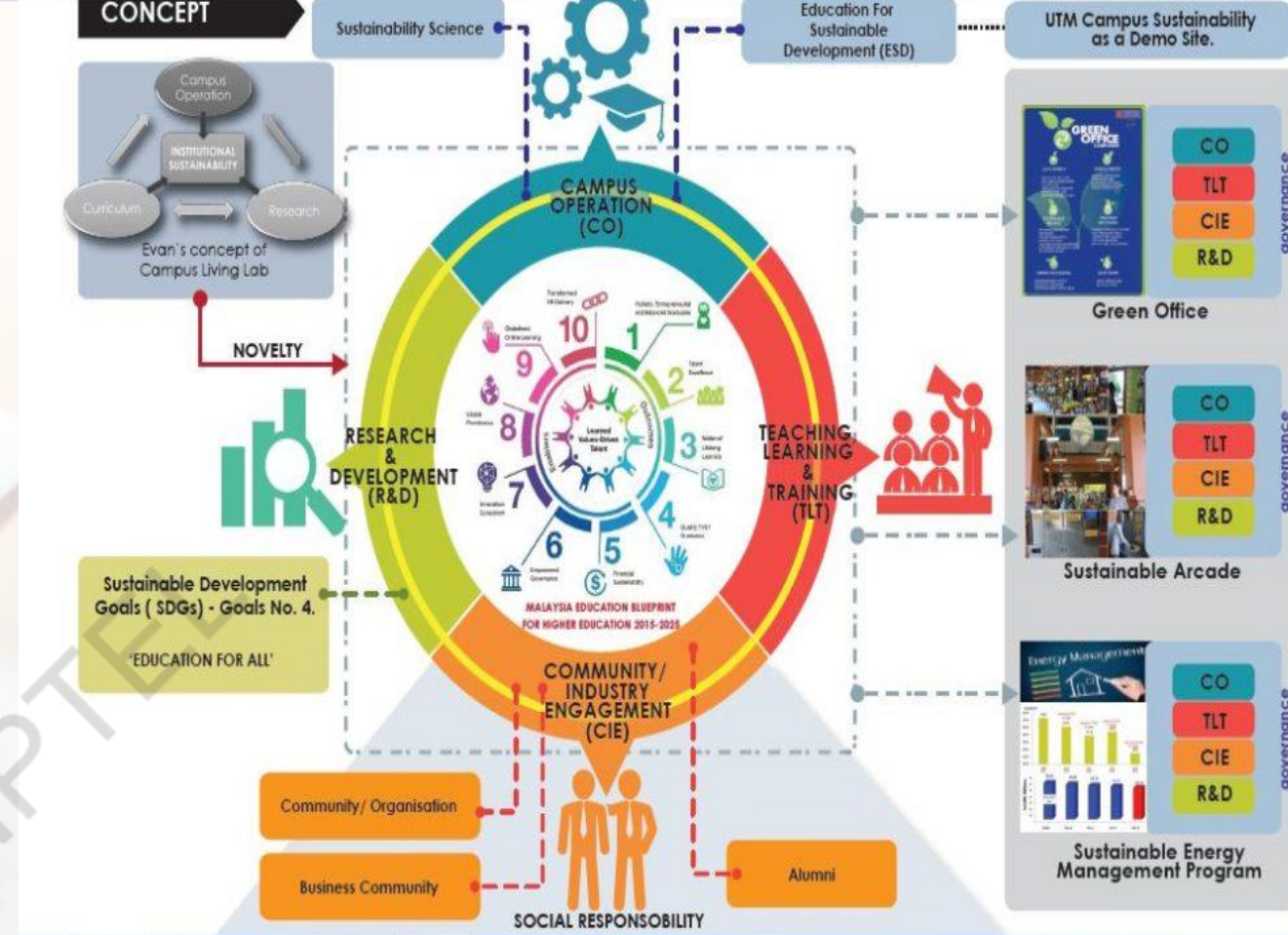
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- **Expand Conscious Awareness**
- **Grounding Conversations and Action in Personal Integrity.** Being clear about one's own identity, principles and intentions before engaging others in the work of change. Frequently **reexamining personal integrity to guide action** in the present moment in the context of complex and ever-changing circumstances.
- **Practicing Consciousness Awareness.** Continually noticing self in relationship with others and the work; **engaging in authentic interaction**, (words and actions); **encouraging joint reflection about what is happening**, has happened, why, and what it means for future thinking and action.



- **Principles of Sustainable Leadership**

- *Sustainable leadership matters, spreads and lasts. It is a shared responsibility, that does not unduly deplete human or financial resources, and that cares for and avoids exerting negative damage on the surrounding educational and community environment. Sustainable leadership has an activist engagement with the forces that affect it, and builds an educational environment of organizational diversity that promotes cross-fertilization of good ideas and successful practices in communities of shared learning and development.*

360-degree Sustainable Leadership



- 1. Sustainable leadership creates and preserves sustaining learning
- 2. *Sustainable leadership secures success over time-Leadership succession* is the last challenge of leadership - It is the challenge of letting go, moving on, and planning for one's own obsolescence.
- 3. *Sustainable leadership sustains the leadership of others*-One way for leaders to leave a lasting legacy is to ensure it is developed with and shared by others
- 4. *Sustainable leadership addresses issues of social justice*-Sustainable leadership benefits all students and schools - not just a few at the expense of the rest
- 5. *Sustainable leadership develops rather than depletes human and material resources*- Sustainable leadership provides *intrinsic rewards and extrinsic incentives* that attract and retain the best and brightest of the leadership pool; and it provides time and opportunity for *leaders to network, learn from and support* each other, as well as *coach and mentor their successors*
- 6. *Sustainable leadership develops environmental diversity and capacity*-Promoters of sustainability cultivate and recreate an environment that has the *capacity to stimulate continuous improvement on a broad front.*



- 7. Sustainable leadership undertakes activist engagement with the environment.

WHAT LEADERSHIP SKILLS DO YOU NEED MOST?

These competencies were voted the most important for all management positions.



SOURCE ZENGER/FOLKMAN

HBR.ORG



Personality Traits of Sustainable Leaders:

- *Caring/morally-driven:* Sustainability leaders demonstrate care for the well-being of humanity and all other forms of life and are guided by a moral compass that incorporates the moral case for sustainable development (i.e., equity today, environmental justice, intergenerational equity and stewardship).
- *Systemic/holistic thinker:* Sustainability leaders are “systems thinkers” with the ability to appreciate the interconnectedness and interdependency of the whole system, at all levels, and to recognize how changes to parts of the system affect the whole. Effective sustainability leaders are able to simultaneously see and balance an array of issues such as business opportunity, customer satisfaction, job creation, pollution reduction and public policy.
- *Enquiring/open-minded:* Sustainability leaders actively seek new knowledge and diverse opinions, including challenges to their own opinions, and are willing to question received wisdom, traditional models of economic growth and the value of their organization’s product or service to society. In particular, sustainability leaders are will to seek information through involvement with community activities and inter-generational engagement.



- *Self-aware/empathetic*: Sustainability leaders have high levels of “emotional intelligence”, including the ability to understand their own emotions and those of others, sincerity, personal humility and ability to listen to others, and the ability to see their own place in and influence on a situation. Sustainability leaders must recognize that they will need to change in order to bring themselves and their organizations to the place in the world where they would like to be.
- *Visionary/courageous*: Sustainability leaders bring inspiration, creativity, optimism and courage to bear in their roles, are driven to produce results, and possess the ability to balance passion and idealism with ambition and pragmatism. Sustainability leaders must also be courageous to seize opportunities and pursue them in the face of great difficulties and with no map to follow other than the one they draw on their own and no absolute knowledge about what the end destination will be.



Beliefs Attitudes and Values of Sustainability Professionals



- Global mindset (includes looking beyond local and national boundaries as well as understanding responsibility as global citizens)
- Rooted in community (a sense of self-worth and rootedness in one's own culture and community)
- Thirst for global awareness (seek out knowledge of world affairs and cultures and realize the interconnectedness of the world)
- Equity (concern for disparities and injustices, a commitment to human rights and to the peaceful resolution of conflict)
- Sense of urgency (desire to move from awareness to knowledge to action, appreciation of finite nature of the planet's resources)
- Passion for sustainability (sense of hope and a positive personal and social perspective on the future)
- Capacity for innovation (encourage decision-making across disciplines, understand interdependence between environmental, economic and social systems, open to new ideas, appreciate role of human ingenuity, challenge the status quo)

What factors enable sustainable leadership?

- Collaboration is key
 - Systems must operate to allow diverse groups to interact; breakdown the silos
- Focus on critical challenges
 - Priorities must be set to tackle most critical challenges first
- Support for change
 - Leaders must operate in institutions that allow for change – the status quo must be questioned



- Embrace a learning culture (striving to continually improve quality of life and your skills)
- Accept trade-offs (among conflicting goals and long-term perspective or complex nature of systems which make it difficult to see the positive or negative impacts of decisions, long-term thinking)
- Tenacity (honor commitments, self-motivated, have a “can-do” attitude, see the bigger picture and longer term)
- Warmth in human relationships (outgoing individual, personable, able to develop close relationships quickly, sense of humor, desire to work in partnerships)
- Respect for diversity (value different ways of working, different cultures and mindsets – while appreciating that humans have universal attributes)
- Science as part of the solution (recognition that technology and science have a lot to offer but alone cannot solve all of our problems)
- Value integrated thinking (whole systems thinking, appreciation of the resilience, fragility and beauty of nature and the interdependence and equal importance of all life forms, valuing biodiversity)
- Commitment to a sustainable lifestyle (personal acceptance of a sustainable lifestyle and a commitment to participation in change, appreciation of the importance and worth of individual responsibility and action)

Source: D. Timmer, J. Creech and C. Buckler, *Becoming a Sustainability Leader* (Winnipeg CN: International Institute for Sustainable Development, 2007), 59.



• Working Style of Sustainable Leaders:

- *Inclusive:* Sustainable leaders are inclusive and encourage collaboration and participation as a means for building commitment. The practice of inclusive leadership includes dialogue and consensus, democratic approaches, coaching and affiliative behavior (i.e. promoting harmony among followers, helping to resolve conflict and making sure followers feel connected to each other)²² and building a climate of peer support and accountability by giving up authority and delegating control over their jobs to employees and then recognizing the achievements of those employees.
- *Visionary:* Visser and Courtice explained that: “the visionary style of leadership brings passion and charisma into the mix. It focuses on challenging and transforming people’s perceptions and expectations and motivating them to transcend narrower forms of self-interest.”²³ Leaders practicing visionary leadership are able to build and share an inspirational vision in ways that help their followers understand and feel how things will be different once the vision has been achieved. Others have argued that because followers are bombarded with new ideas and other complexities throughout their lives, the only way for visionaries to get through is to “think and lead big” in order to make the emotional links with those they seek to influence.²⁴



- *Creative:* Sustainable leaders need to be creative and willing and able to apply that creativity to a number of different roles in the transformation change process: designer, architect, innovator, game changer and systems transformer. Visser and Courtice noted that creativity can be seen when sustainability leaders act as systems re-designers when adopting and implementing principles of cradle-to-cradle design and production and extend them throughout their supply chains.
- *Altruistic:* Sustainability leaders are focused on transcending self-interest and focusing their attentions and activities on the collective good, characteristics that are in line with altruistic leadership styles such as servant or “quiet” leadership. Greenleaf described effective servant leadership as a leader providing his or her service to followers with the goal of helping the followers to growth and become healthier, wiser, freer and more autonomous.²⁵ According to Collins, quiet leaders

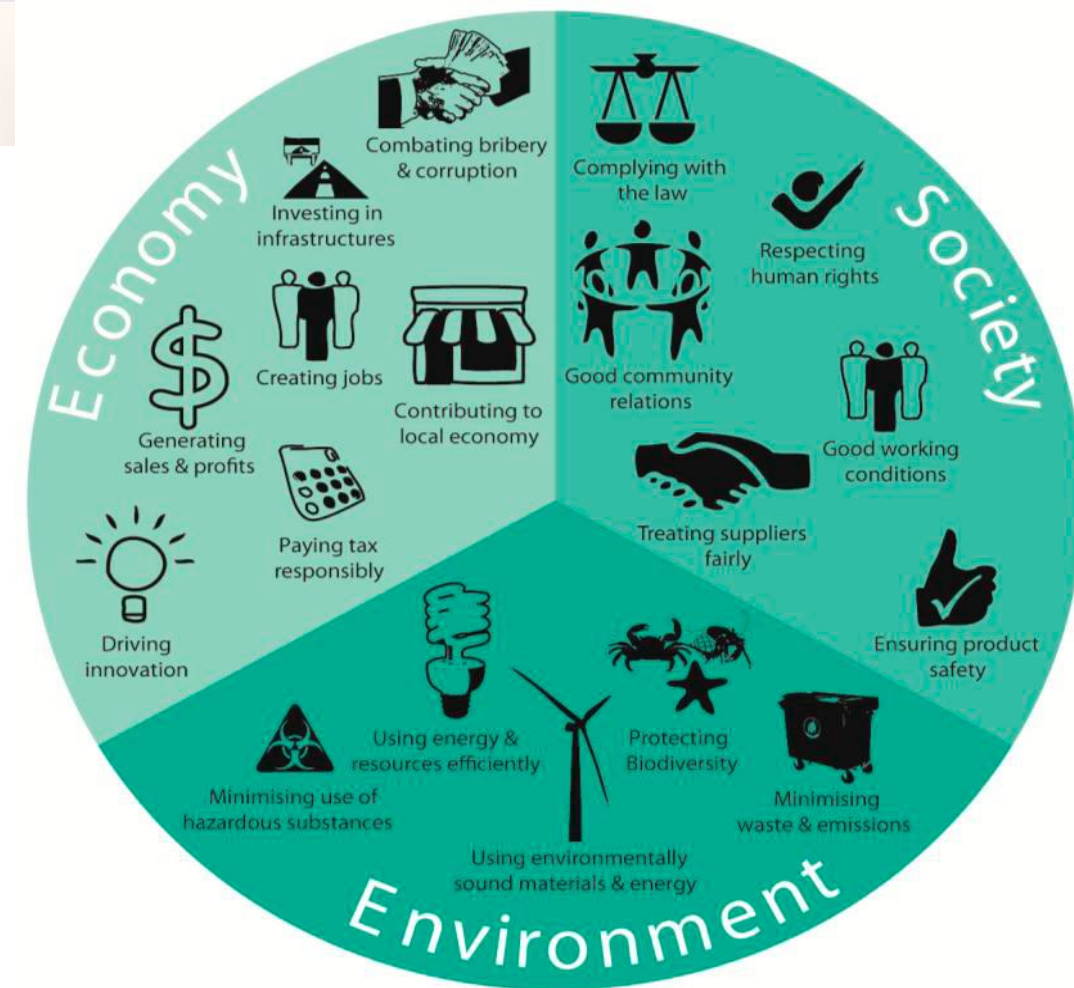
are self-effacing, quiet, reserved and shy and lead with a mix of personal humility and professional will.²⁶

- *Radical:* Radical, or “missionary”, leadership is an approaches that differs significantly from quiet leadership and was described by Visser and Courtice as involving taking risks, acting like a revolutionary or activist and challenging the status quo. Visser and Courtice referred to radical leaders as campaigners or crusaders for important causes who thrived on being daring and different and undeterred by the challenges of making an impact.



• Sustainable Leadership Skills:

- *Manage complexity:* Visser and Courtice advised that sustainability leaders must be skilled at analyzing, synthesizing, and translating complex issues, responding to risk, uncertainty and dilemmas, recognizing and seizing opportunities and resolving problems and conflicts. The key for sustainability leader is being able to make sound choices in the face of inherent complexity and uncertainty.
- *Communicate vision:* Effective sustainability leaders have good communication skills and are able to share a long-term vision and facilitate dialog that inspires action and change and creates shared meaning. Relevant techniques include active listening, emotional intelligence and reflection. The vision must be inspired by the leader's passion and suitable for driving the company's economic engine.
- *Exercise judgement:* According to Visser and Courtice, sustainability leaders are skilled to make good and decisive decisions in a timely fashion, including prioritizing, making difficult choices and handling dilemmas. Good judgment is particularly important in times of crisis when leaders must inspire their followers, set expectations and communicate effectively and in a timely manner with stakeholders.



• Professional Skills required for Sustainable Organizations:

- Staff and team management (with the ability to delegate and manage complex tasks and competing priorities)
- Long-term planning (orientation to and planning for longer-term outcomes, as compared to an immediate-results orientation)
- Project management (process of setting and delivering project goals, objectives, tasks, timelines, results and assessment against objectives)
- Financial skills (understand the organization's bottom line, budget development—including cost estimates—and other fiscal responsibilities)
- Donor or client relations (management of donor or client relations, including reporting skills)
- Communication skills (excellent written and oral communications skills, proficiency in a second language)
- Translating complex ideas (ability to "translate" complex or scientific issues into simple and clear messages)
- Analytical rigor (including the ability to frame appropriate research questions or policy advice)
- Knowledge management (literacy in electronic communications, virtual collaboration and other knowledge management skills)
- Influencing strategy (understanding of how to influence and promote change, including what it means to be a "change agent" for sustainability)
- Awareness of stakeholder roles (understanding the roles of different actors in sustainability, including the importance of involving stakeholders in decision-making)
- Geo-political awareness (understanding of the geo-political context in which you are working)
- Facilitation skills (skilled at mediating different interests, including good listening, clarifying, questioning and responding skills)





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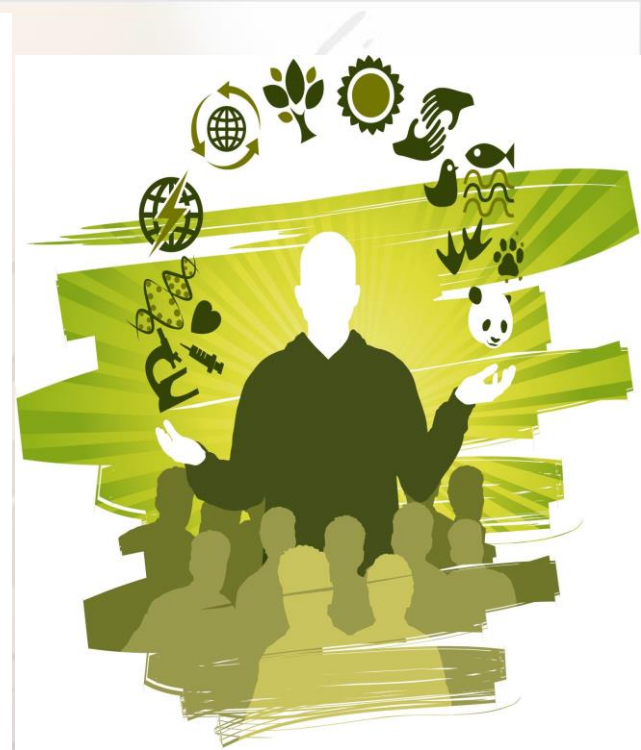


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Lean Leadership

Jagyasi argued that in order to use the lean startup process effectively, and put startups on a path of sustainable growth that can be maintained, it is necessary to have “lean leadership with a futuristic vision and well defined strategies”. According to Jagyasi, lean leadership was based on five basic principles:

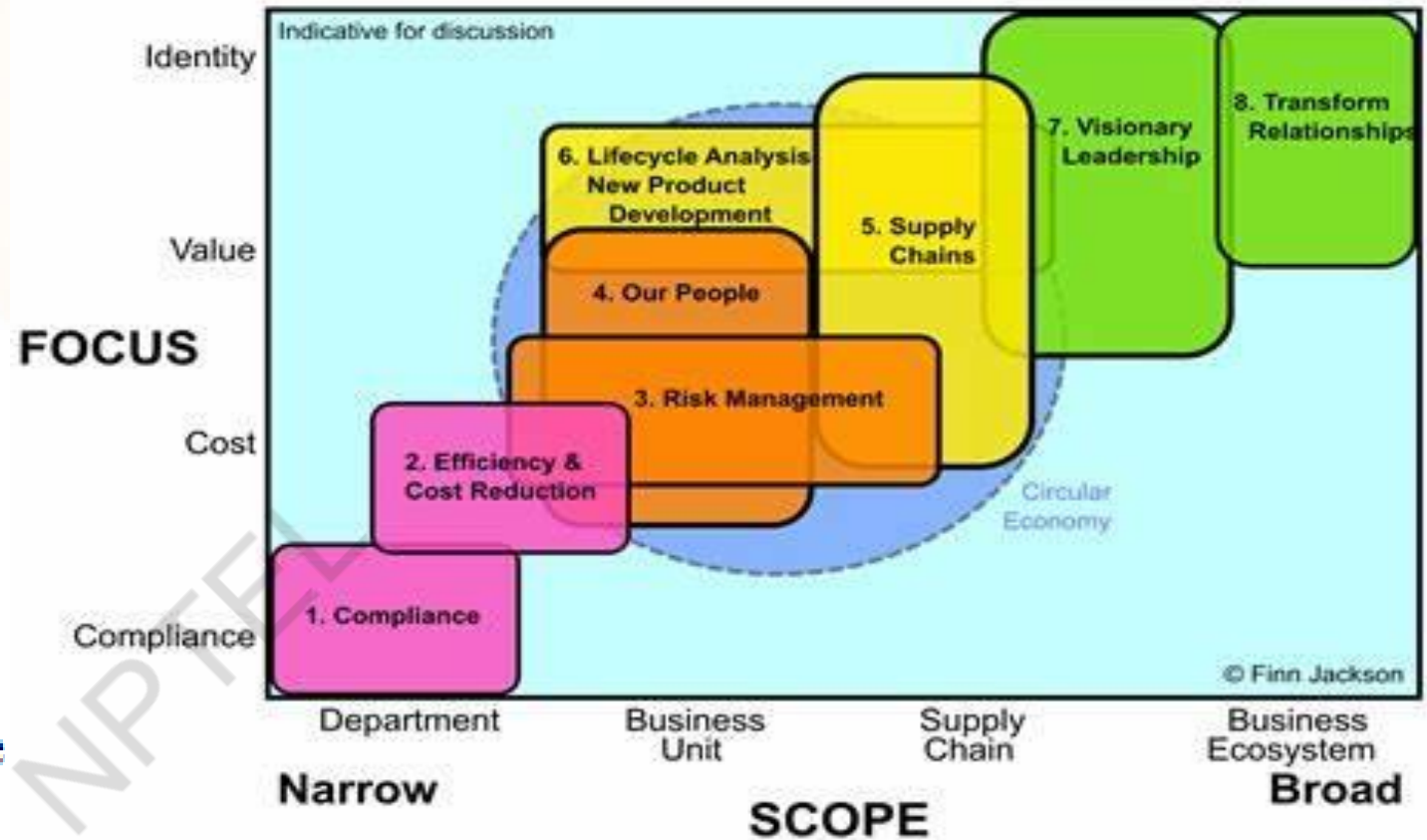
- **Identify the core performers:** Lean leaders must be able to quickly identify those core members of the team with the ability to get things done in the system and fetch unexpected rewards and nurture them properly along with timely rewards and incentives.
- **Learning from the data:** Smart lean leaders have the ability to use the data collected from the lean startup process intelligently to plan for new innovations in the market, study a market segment, improve and accelerate the decision making process and enhance the learning capacity of the organization.
- **Maintain a trimmed management system:** A lean management team fosters learning and growth and lean leaders should avoid creating an overcrowded management system that tends to restrict innovation and create conflicts of interest that decrease the productivity level of the organization. Before adding to the management team, a clear case must be made that the new addition will create real value.
- **Incentivizing the innovations:** Lean leaders must be able to properly align incentives and rewards to the startup's strategic goals and should also create incentives and key performance indicators that encourage and motivate the most innovative members of the team.
- **Directing the route:** The lean leader must be an efficient driver of the “startup vehicle”, which means being able to detect the points to slow down, shift gears, change the course (i.e., “pivot”) or persevere.



- Learning attitude: Willing to learn and not only command
- Good understanding level: Good listener and willing to understand.
- Believes in evidence based practice
- Maintaining a continuous and sustainable lean thinking
- Always open to communication
- Displays strong commitment towards consistency, discipline and outcome
- Advocate cause-effect relationship
- Possess a high leadership personality

Source: P. Jagyasi, "Lean leadership for startup companies" (August 14, 2017), <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/lean-leadership-startup-companies-dr-prem-jagyasi-drprem-com>. For

Mapping Sustainable Leadership



The Sustainable Leadership Pyramid

